FUTURES MATTER EDUCATION

Futures Matter - Northwood, 122 Emily Street, Highgate, Birmingham, B12 0XJ

Mobile Phone Policy

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1.0 INTRODUCTION AND AIMS

Futures Matter - Northwood recognises that mobile phones, including smart phones, are an important part of everyday life for our pupils, parents and carers, and staff. They can also bring risks for the pupils we support, many of whom are vulnerable online and some of whom find it hard to regulate their use of technology.

Our school is a **mobile phone-free environment by default.** Anything other than this is by exception only. Throughout this policy, 'mobile phones' means mobile phones and similar devices, including smartwatches and any other device with communication or smart technology.

This policy aims to:

- make sure our school is mobile phone-free by default
- promote the safe, responsible and lawful use of mobile phones, where they are allowed
- set clear guidelines for the use of mobile phones by pupils, staff, parents and carers, visitors and volunteers
- support our other policies, especially those on safeguarding, behaviour and online safety

This policy also addresses the challenges that mobile phones can bring to school, including:

- risks to child protection, including bullying, sexual harassment, and viewing or sharing indecent images or other harmful content
- data protection issues
- disruption to learning, and to pupils' regulation and relationships
- the risk of theft, loss or damage
- the appropriate use of technology for learning

2.0 LEGISLATION AND GUIDANCE

This policy meets the requirements of section 36 of the Children's Wellbeing and Schools Act 2026 and the Department for Education (DfE) statutory guidance on mobile phones in schools, which says that all schools should be mobile phone-free environments by default, with anything else by exception only. We follow that guidance from 1 September 2026. It also reflects the DfE's behaviour guidance and Keeping Children Safe in Education (KCSIE) 2026, which says that it is for headteachers to decide how best to achieve a phone-free school in their own context.

- Mobile Phones in Schools, DfE statutory guidance
- Behaviour in Schools - Advice for Headteachers and School Staff, DfE, February 2024
- Keeping Children Safe in Education (KCSIE) 2026
- Searching, Screening and Confiscation - Advice for Schools, DfE, July 2022
- Sections 91 and 94 of the Education and Inspections Act 2006, which allow us to discipline pupils and confiscate their property
- The Education (Independent School Standards) Regulations 2014

- The Equality Act 2010 and the Children and Families Act 2014, which require us to make reasonable adjustments for pupils with SEND

3.0 ROLES AND RESPONSIBILITIES

The Head Teacher is responsible for monitoring this policy, reviewing it every year, deciding any exceptions, and holding staff and pupils accountable for its implementation. The Head Teacher also answers any questions or concerns from parents and carers quickly, and explains clearly why we prohibit mobile phones during the school day.

All staff (including teachers, support staff, supply staff and agency staff) are required to enforce this policy actively, and to challenge any breach of the mobile phone rules immediately and consistently. Volunteers, and anyone else engaged by the school, must tell a member of staff if they see or know about a breach.

The Proprietor and the Chair of School Governance Board approve this policy, and consider the monitoring information at their reviews of behaviour and safeguarding.

4.0 USE OF MOBILE PHONES BY STAFF

The DfE's guidance says that staff should not use their own mobile phones for personal reasons in front of pupils during the school day. We expect staff to model the behaviour we ask of our pupils.

Personal mobile phones. Staff (including volunteers, contractors and anyone else engaged by the school) must not use their personal mobile phones during the school day while pupils are present. Personal phones are kept out of sight and on silent. Use is limited to non-contact time, in areas where pupils are not present, such as the school office or staff area. There may be circumstances in which it is appropriate for a member of staff to have their phone during contact time for personal reasons, for example:

- emergency contact by their child, or their child's school
- an acutely ill dependent or family member

The Head Teacher decides case by case whether to allow special arrangements. If these are not needed, family members can use the school office number, 0121 835 1360, as the point of emergency contact.

Data protection. Staff must not use their personal mobile phones to process personal data or any other confidential school information, including entering such data into generative artificial intelligence (AI) tools such as chatbots. Please see our Data Protection Policy and Online Safety and Acceptable Use Policy.

Safeguarding. Staff must not give their personal contact details to parents, carers or pupils, including by connecting through social media and messaging apps, and must avoid publicising their contact details on any social media platform or website. Staff must not use their personal mobile phones to take photographs or recordings of pupils, their work, or anything else that could identify a pupil. If photographs or recordings are needed for a lesson, trip or activity, staff use school equipment. Please see our Staff Code of Conduct.

Using personal phones for work. In some circumstances it may be appropriate for staff to use a personal phone for work in front of pupils. These include:

- multi-factor authentication to access school systems

- an emergency evacuation, lockdown or other emergency, where the school's normal communication systems are not available (see our Emergency and Business Continuity Plan)
- supervising an off-site trip, where the school mobile phone is unavailable or has failed (see our Educational Visits Policy)

In these circumstances staff use their phone in an appropriate and professional way, in line with the Staff Code of Conduct. They do not use it to take photographs or recordings of pupils, and they do not use it to contact parents or carers. Contact with parents and carers is made through the school office or the school mobile phone.

Work phones. The school provides a mobile phone for visit leaders and for other work purposes. Only authorised staff may use school phones, and access must not be given to anyone without authorisation. Staff use school phones only for work, for calls, email and other communication, and make sure that all communication and conduct linked to the device is appropriate and professional.

Security. Staff must secure their personal phones, and any work phone, with a password or pin code. Failure to do so could lead to a data breach.

Sanctions. Staff who do not follow this policy may face disciplinary action. Please see our Staff Code of Conduct and the staff disciplinary arrangements.

5.0 USE OF MOBILE PHONES BY PUPILS

Pupils do not use mobile phones during the school day. This includes lessons, the time between lessons, break times and lunchtime, unless a member of staff has explicitly agreed it, for example for a specific medical reason.

Our approach. Pupils who bring a mobile phone to school must have this agreed in advance with the Head Teacher. The phone is switched off and handed in on entry, it is stored securely during the school day, and it is returned to the pupil at the end of the day. Pupils are told about this in their induction, and we remind them as often as needed. We work with parents and carers so that they understand the reasons for our approach.

To confirm: where handed-in phones and smartwatches are stored (for example a locked cabinet in the school office), who logs them in and out, and what the system is for a pupil who arrives by taxi or transport.

Smartwatches. Smartwatches can send messages, make calls, take photographs and connect to the internet, and they can look like ordinary watches. Pupils may not wear a smartwatch in school unless it has been agreed as an exception. A pupil who arrives wearing one is asked to hand it in in the same way as a phone, and it is stored and returned in the same way.

Exceptions. We may agree an exception where there is a documented safeguarding or medical need, or a pupil travels to or from school alone. For example:

- a pupil who uses a phone or smart device to manage a medical condition, such as a glucose monitor
- a young carer who needs to be contactable
- a pupil who travels to and from school alone and needs their phone for safety on the journey (the phone is handed in on arrival)

To ask for an exception, a parent or carer contacts the Head Teacher. Permission is recorded on the permission form (Appendix 2), and the pupil follows the pupil code of conduct (Appendix 1). We consider reasonable adjustments for pupils with SEND, and for pupils who find handing in a phone very hard. The school can withdraw permission if the code of conduct is not followed.

Teaching pupils about phones. Through PSHE and our online safety teaching, pupils learn about the risks of mobile phones, including to focus and learning, classroom disruption, bullying, sexual harassment, and harmful or AI-generated content. We encourage pupils to see a phone-free environment as a good thing. We also teach pupils how to stay safe online away from school.

Sanctions. If a pupil is found with a phone that has not been handed in, or uses a phone in breach of this policy, staff will calmly ask them to hand it over, and we respond in line with our Behaviour, Rewards and Sanctions Policy. We do not use detentions. Our response is proportionate and focuses on repair and learning. It may include:

- a calm reminder of the expectations, and a conversation about why the rule matters
- confiscation of the phone, which is kept securely and returned to the pupil at the end of the day, or to a parent or carer where the Head Teacher decides it is proportionate (the Head Teacher may confiscate for as long as is proportionate)
- a call to parents and carers, and a plan to help the pupil to meet the expectations
- repair work, and support from a trusted adult

We consider any special circumstances, including age, special educational needs and disability. We also consider whether the pupil's behaviour could mean they are suffering, or at risk of, harm. If so, staff follow our Safeguarding and Child Protection Policy and speak to the Designated Safeguarding Lead (DSL) or a deputy, who will consider whether pastoral support, early help or a referral to children's social care is appropriate.

Searching and examining phones. Staff have the power to search a pupil and to examine the data and files on a phone where there is good reason to do so, for example if they have reason to believe it contains pornographic images or has been, or is being, used to commit an offence or cause harm to another person. Only the Head Teacher or a member of staff authorised by them carries out a search, in line with section 11 of our Behaviour, Rewards and Sanctions Policy. Inappropriate files may be deleted before the phone is returned.

Criminal conduct. Some conduct, bullying or harassment using a phone is criminal. We take it extremely seriously and will involve the police or other agencies as appropriate. This includes making or sharing nudes or semi-nudes, including images that are altered or generated using AI such as 'deepfakes', upskirting, threats of violence or assault, and abusive messages directed at someone because of their ethnicity, religious beliefs or sexual orientation.

Examinations. Mobile phones and similar devices are not allowed in any internal or external examination or test. A pupil who has one must hand it in before entering the room.

6.0 PARENTS, CARERS, VOLUNTEERS AND VISITORS

Parents and carers are encouraged to reinforce this policy at home, including the risks of mobile phone use and the benefits of a phone-free environment. Advice for parents and carers on children's online safety is available from Kids Online World.

Parents and carers, visitors and volunteers (including contractors and members of the governing board) must follow this policy as it applies to staff when they are on site during the school day. This means:

- not taking pictures or recordings of pupils or staff, unless it is of their own child at a public event
- using any photographs or recordings for personal use only, and not posting them on social media without consent
- not using phones in lessons, when working with pupils, or while children are present
- keeping phones on silent, and using them only in areas where pupils are not present, which at present is the school office

Visitors and volunteers are told the rules when they sign in at reception and are given an information slip (Appendix 3). A copy of this policy is available from the school office and on our website.

Trips. Parents, carers or volunteers who help supervise trips must not use their phone to contact other parents or carers, or to take photographs or recordings of pupils, their work, or anything else that could identify a pupil. They help to enforce our rules for pupils, but must refer any proposed sanction to a member of staff, as they do not have the power to search or confiscate devices.

Contacting pupils. Parents and carers must use the school office, on 0121 835 1360, as the first point of contact if they need to get in touch with their child during the school day. They must not try to contact their child on their own mobile phone.

7.0 LOSS, THEFT OR DAMAGE

Pupils who bring phones to school must make sure that they are labelled and switched off, ready to be handed in. Pupils are encouraged to protect their phones with a password or pin code.

The school accepts no responsibility for mobile phones that are lost, damaged or stolen on school premises or transport, on school visits or trips, or while pupils travel to or from school. We make parents, carers and pupils aware of this through the permission form (Appendix 2), our Home-School Agreement, a notice in the school office, and by giving a copy of this policy to new pupils and families. Confiscated phones are stored securely in the school office, and the school is responsible for them while they are in our care.

Lost phones should be handed to the school office. The school will then try to contact the owner.

8.0 MONITORING AND REVIEW

The school is committed to making sure that this policy has a positive impact on pupils' education, behaviour and welfare. The Head Teacher reviews this policy every year, and sooner if the law or guidance changes. When reviewing it we take into account:

- feedback from parents and carers, and from pupils
- feedback from staff
- records of behaviour and safeguarding incidents involving phones
- advice from the DfE, the local authority and other relevant organisations

Anyone with a concern about this policy should tell the Head Teacher, Benjamin Neasom, at the school office on 0121 835 1360.

9.0 RELATED POLICIES

- Behaviour, Rewards and Sanctions Policy
- Safeguarding and Child Protection Policy
- Online Safety and Acceptable Use Policy
- Filtering and Monitoring Policy
- Data Protection Policy
- Staff Code of Conduct
- Educational Visits Policy
- Emergency and Business Continuity Plan

10.0 APPENDICES

Appendix 1: Pupil Code of Conduct for Pupils Allowed a Phone in School

Appendix 2: Permission Form to Bring a Phone to School

Appendix 3: Information Slip for Visitors

APPENDIX 1: PUPIL CODE OF CONDUCT

This agreement is for pupils who have been given permission to bring a phone or smart device to school because of exceptional circumstances. If you bring your phone to school, you agree to follow these rules.

- I will switch my phone off (not just on silent) and hand it in when I arrive, unless a member of staff has agreed that I need it for a specific reason, for example for my health.
- I will not use my phone at any time during the school day, including lessons, between lessons, break and lunchtime, unless a member of staff allows it.
- I will never use my phone in the toilets or changing rooms.
- I will not take photographs or recordings, video or audio, of staff or other pupils.
- I will not share my contact details with people I do not know, and I will not share other people's details without their consent.
- I will not share my password or pin code with anyone else.
- I will not use my phone to bully, frighten or harass anyone, including by messages, email or social media. These rules apply even when I am not in school.
- I will not use rude, vulgar, obscene or unkind language when I use my phone or social media.
- I will not use my phone to view or share pornography or other harmful content, and I will not make or share nudes or semi-nudes, including AI-generated images or 'deepfakes'. These can be criminal offences.
- If a member of staff asks me to switch off or hand over my phone, I will do it. I understand that refusing is a breach of the behaviour policy.
- I will not take my phone into an examination or test. I will hand it in first.
- I understand that the school can take away my permission if I do not follow these rules.

PUPIL AGREEMENT	
Pupil name and date:	
Pupil signature:	
Parent or carer signature:	

APPENDIX 2: PERMISSION FORM TO BRING A PHONE TO SCHOOL

We use this form when we agree an exception to our mobile phone-free approach. It is signed by the parent or carer and, where appropriate, by the pupil.

PERMISSION TO BRING A PHONE TO SCHOOL	
Pupil name:	
Year group or class:	
Parent or carer name(s):	
The school has agreed to allow the pupil to bring their phone to school because they (tick or delete as needed): travel to and from school alone / are a young carer / need the phone to support their medical needs / are attending a trip where phones are allowed / attend an activity where a phone is needed:	
Details of the agreed arrangements (handing in, storage and any specific use):	
I have read the Mobile Phone Policy and the pupil code of conduct. I understand that the school accepts no responsibility for phones that are lost, damaged or stolen, and that the school can withdraw permission if the policy is not followed. Parent or carer signature and date:	
Pupil signature (where appropriate) and date:	
For school use: authorised by (Head Teacher) and date:	

APPENDIX 3: INFORMATION SLIP FOR VISITORS

We give this slip to every visitor and volunteer when they sign in. A full copy of the policy is available from the school office.

USE OF MOBILE PHONES AND SIMILAR DEVICES IN OUR SCHOOL	
Our school is a mobile phone-free environment by default.	
Please keep your mobile phone on silent or vibrate while you are on the school site.	
Please do not use your phone where pupils are present. If you must use your phone, you may go to the school office.	
Do not take photos or recordings of pupils (unless it is your own child at a public event), or of staff.	
Do not use your phone in lessons, when working with pupils or while children are present.	
The school accepts no responsibility for phones that are lost, damaged or stolen while you are on the school site.	